



FREE GUIDE · FOR PHARMACIES

The Pharmacy's Guide to Compliant Waste Disposal.

From reverse distribution and controlled returns to
hazardous drugs — recover credit and stay compliant.

DEA-REGISTERED

EPA-COMPLIANT

NO CONTRACT

CERTIFICATE OF DESTRUCTION

Compliance, made simple.

Turn drug waste into a compliance win.

Pharmacies handle the widest drug-waste mix of any business — expired inventory, patient returns, controlled substances, and RCRA-hazardous drugs. Handled well, it's not just a cost: reverse distribution can recover manufacturer credit on returnable stock. This guide covers every stream, the DEA paperwork, and how to turn returns into credit while destroying the rest compliantly.

The good news

As a DEA-registered reverse distributor, we recover credit on returnable Rx and destroy the rest — controlled and non-controlled — with Form 222/41 handled and a Certificate of Destruction every time. No contract.

AT A GLANCE

Who regulates what.

Agency	What it covers in your practice
OSHA	Bloodborne Pathogens Standard — sharps handling, containers, and annual staff training.
EPA	RCRA — hazardous pharmaceutical waste identification, segregation, and destruction.
DEA	Controlled substances — non-retrievable destruction and DEA Form 41 documentation.
DOT	Safe shipping of regulated medical and pharmaceutical waste in transit.
State	Health-department and environmental rules that vary by state.

THE STREAMS

Every stream, in depth.

Below is each regulated stream your practice produces — what belongs in it, what does not, the rule behind it, how to dispose of it, and a tip to stay clean.

WASTE STREAM 01

Reverse distribution & returns

Your biggest opportunity, not just an expense. Returnable expired and unused Rx can be sent back to the manufacturer or wholesaler for financial credit — the rest is destroyed. Sorting the two correctly is where the money is.

GOES IN THIS STREAM

- Expired / unused returnable Rx
- Overstock & discontinued inventory
- Manufacturer recalls
- Both brand & generic stock

DOES NOT GO HERE

- Opened / adulterated product (destroy only)
- Patient-owned meds
- Sharps

THE RULE · Returnable items are processed for manufacturer credit; non-returnable items are rendered non-retrievable with documentation.

DISPOSE WITH · Pharmaceutical reverse distribution — credit recovered, the rest destroyed.

Tip

Don't pre-sort into the trash — items you'd have thrown away may still be credit-eligible.

WASTE STREAM 02

Controlled substances

Schedule II–V expired stock, returns, and wasted product. The DEA governs both the transfer and the destruction.

GOES IN THIS STREAM

- Expired / unused Schedule II–V stock
- Patient returns of controls (per program)
- Partial & wasted doses

DOES NOT GO HERE

- Non-controlled meds (pharmaceutical kit)
- Sharps

THE RULE · DEA — Form 222 for Schedule II transfers, Form 41 for surrendered controls, and non-retrievable destruction with records.

DISPOSE WITH · Controlled-substance mail-back kit / reverse distribution, to DEA standards.

Tip

We're a DEA-registered reverse distributor — the credential that makes taking back your controls legal.

WASTE STREAM 03

RCRA-hazardous drugs

A surprising number of common drugs are federally hazardous waste — and can't go in normal pharmaceutical waste.

GOES IN THIS STREAM

- P-listed (warfarin $\geq 0.3\%$, nicotine, epinephrine, physostigmine)
- U-listed drugs
- Characteristic waste (ignitable, toxic)
- Certain chemotherapy agents

DOES NOT GO HERE

- Non-hazardous pharmaceuticals
- Controlled substances (own path)

THE RULE · EPA RCRA — identify P/U-listed and characteristic drugs, segregate, and destroy to EPA standards; know your generator status.

DISPOSE WITH · RCRA-hazardous mail-back kit.

Tip

Nicotine gum/patches and epinephrine are P-listed — easy to miss and a common citation.

WASTE STREAM 04

Pharmaceutical waste (non-hazardous)

Everyday expired non-controlled, non-hazardous medications.

GOES IN THIS STREAM

- Expired non-controlled, non-hazardous Rx
- OTC & compounded non-haz product
- Samples

DOES NOT GO HERE

- Controlled substances
- RCRA-hazardous drugs
- Sharps

THE RULE · Do not drain-dispose; destroy with documentation.

DISPOSE WITH · Pharmaceutical waste mail-back kit.

Tip

Segregate hazardous drugs first — everything else routes here.

WASTE STREAM 05

Sharps

From immunizations and point-of-care testing.

GOES IN THIS STREAM

- Immunization needles & syringes
- Lancets
- Point-of-care testing sharps

DOES NOT GO HERE

- Non-sharp meds
- Glass vials without needles (per policy)

THE RULE · OSHA — FDA-cleared, puncture-resistant containers; annual training if staff are exposed.

DISPOSE WITH · Sharps mail-back kit.

Tip

Immunizing pharmacies generate more sharps than they expect — size your kit accordingly.

YOUR CHECKLIST

The pharmacy compliance checklist.

- ☐ Reverse distribution set up — returnables credited, the rest destroyed.
- ☐ Controlled substances: Form 222/41 completed, non-retrievable destruction.
- ☐ RCRA-hazardous drugs (P/U-listed + characteristic) identified and segregated.
- ☐ Non-hazardous pharmaceutical waste destroyed with documentation.
- ☐ Immunization sharps in FDA-cleared containers.
- ☐ Certificates of Destruction and return records retained per your state's rules.

QUESTIONS PHARMACISTS ASK

Your pharmacy questions, answered.

What is reverse distribution and can we actually get credit?

Yes. Returnable expired or unused Rx is sent back to the manufacturer or wholesaler for financial credit; non-returnable items are destroyed. Done right, it recovers real money you'd otherwise write off.

How do we handle controlled-substance returns?

Through a DEA-registered reverse distributor — that's us. We handle Form 222 for Schedule II transfers and Form 41 for surrendered controls, with non-retrievable destruction.

Which drugs are RCRA-hazardous?

P-listed (e.g., warfarin $\geq 0.3\%$, nicotine, epinephrine), U-listed, and characteristic wastes. They must be segregated from normal pharmaceutical waste — we'll help you identify them.

Do you handle both brand and generic returns?

Yes — all returnable stock is processed for credit where eligible, brand and generic.

Do we need a contract?

No — no contract and no minimums.

THE EASY WAY

Handle it with mail-back.

Easy Rx Cycle handles pharmacy waste by prepaid mail-back or scheduled pickup for higher volume. Returnable Rx is processed for manufacturer credit; controlled and non-controlled waste is destroyed non-retrievable with a Certificate of Destruction. Form 222/41 handled. No contract.

QUICK REFERENCE · WHICH KIT FOR WHICH STREAM

Waste stream	The right path
Returnable Rx	Reverse distribution (credit recovery)
Controlled substances	Controlled kit / reverse distribution (Form 222/41)
RCRA-hazardous drugs	RCRA-hazardous mail-back kit
Non-hazardous Rx	Pharmaceutical waste kit
Immunization sharps	Sharps mail-back kit

Prefer pickup, or higher volume?

Mail-back suits many independents, but chains, high-volume, or multi-site pharmacies often prefer scheduled pickup and centralized reverse distribution. We'll size a program for you — get a quote at easyrxcycle.com/get-a-quote or call 501-904-2929.



WHY PHARMACIES CHOOSE EASY RX CYCLE

- No contract, no minimums — buy as you need
- Flat-rate pricing — no fuel or hidden surcharges
- One vendor for every stream you generate
- DEA-registered, EPA- & OSHA-aligned destruction
- A Certificate of Destruction on every single order

Ready to simplify your pharmacy waste?

Shop mail-back kits with prices, or get a custom quote for pickup and higher volume. No contract, cancel anytime.

501-904-2929 · sales@easyrxcycle.com · easyrxcycle.com/shop